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For the President

8 October 2026

Today's Brief

IRAN: Pentagon told to finish preparing for renewed major combat operations as Tehran escalates in the Gulf.

YEMEN-SAUDI ARABIA: Houthi strikes on Riyadh and Abha airports kill three; Riyadh courts Syrian troops for its counteroffensive.

RUSSIA-UKRAINE: Kramatorsk bus strike kills 33 a day after a mass missile barrage; Kyiv hits a Yandex data center.

EUROPE: Denmark and the UK-Germany partnership harden against Russian sabotage; EU clears record sanctions; Nord Stream talks surface.

KOREAN PENINSULA: Seoul recalls its ambassador from Kyiv and flies its first hypersonic weapon.

HORN OF AFRICA: Eritrean forces enter Tigray; Ethiopian drones respond.

RUSSIA: WHO still lacks answers on the Irkutsk plague-lab death as Moscow closes the case.

NOTES: Maduro torture indictment; Myanmar talks; UK consulate in Jerusalem; Kenya Ebola; Spain strike call.

For the President
8 October 2026



US Moves Toward Renewed Major Combat Operations Against Iran as Tehran Escalates in the Gulf

We assess that the United States is closer to resuming large-scale strikes on Iran than at any point since the April ceasefire, and that Tehran is escalating in the Gulf in a bid to raise the cost before Washington decides. Press reporting citing US officials indicates the Department of War directed Central Command several days ago to complete preparations to resume major combat operations; no date has been set and the President has not decided. The White House has separately asked the Pentagon for strike options that could be executed before the 3 November midterms, and US and Israeli officials say any action could also precede Israel's election a week earlier. Any renewed campaign would likely focus on energy, infrastructure, and nuclear-related targets.

- The President's public posture hardened on 7 October. At a San Antonio rally he said a deal "isn't really something that I want to do," while adding that Special Envoy Witkoff was still working the file. Vice President Vance a day earlier said Iran must make a "meaningful" cut to its enrichment capacity to end the war and questioned why Tehran needs 60-percent material. We judge Washington is keeping a diplomatic track open chiefly to shape the narrative around a strike decision, not because a deal is near.
- Tehran is answering with pressure at sea. A tanker, identified by maritime-intelligence firms as the Antigua-flagged *Acers*, was hit by multiple projectiles about 51 nautical miles north of Qatar at roughly 1900 GMT on 7 October, with casualties reported; it is the deepest-Gulf attack in about a month. UKMTO logged nine attacks in and around the Strait of Hormuz in the first seven days of October, half the total for all of September.
- An IRGC adviser claimed on 7 October that the strait is "closed" and under Iranian control and warned that transit routes Tehran deems illegal would soon be shut. CENTCOM publicly rebutted the claim, stating that commercial traffic, including roughly 20 million barrels of crude, was moving through the strait. We assess the IRGC statement is directed at insurers and shippers as much as at Washington: raising perceived risk is the cheapest lever Tehran has left.

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- Markets are pricing the risk. Brent rose as much as 5.7 percent on 7 October, its largest intraday move in nearly a month, and traded above \$105. With inventories thin despite the G7's 100-million-barrel release announced on 2 October, a resumption of strikes would probably push prices sharply higher within hours.
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Secretary Hegseth awarded the Presidential Unit Citation to the Abraham Lincoln Carrier Strike Group on 7 October, citing 40 days of combat operations and the maritime blockade of Iran under Operation Epic Fury; the group is returning from a 321-day deployment. For Washington, the decision point is now a political as much as a military one: the force posture to strike exists, and the costs of waiting (continued tanker attacks, elevated fuel prices into the midterms) are mounting. Watch for a presidential call with Gulf leaders and for Israeli cabinet movement; either would likely precede a decision by days, not weeks.

- Iran's leadership opacity remains a planning problem. The President said on 6 October that no one knows who is running Iran; Tehran's foreign ministry insists Washington knows its counterpart. We expect any Iranian response to a US strike to be set by the IRGC rather than the civilian government.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, the Office of Naval Intelligence, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

For the President
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Houthi Strikes on Saudi Airports Widen the Yemen War as Riyadh Courts Syrian Troops

We assess the Houthis have deliberately shifted to Saudi civil aviation to impose political cost on Riyadh's ground counteroffensive, and that the campaign will likely intensify as long as that offensive advances. Saudi Arabia's civil-aviation authority confirmed that Houthi attacks on Abha International Airport and King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh on 6 and 7 October killed three people (Moroccan, Algerian, and Sudanese residents) and wounded 36, with dozens of flights delayed or cancelled. Explosions were heard again in Riyadh on 8 October; the Houthis claimed a second strike on King Khalid, and the coalition said it intercepted a ballistic missile north of the capital and destroyed a launch platform in Sanaa.

- Saudi-backed Yemeni government forces launched a large ground operation over the weekend to retake Red Sea coastal territory the Houthis seized last month, including positions around the Bab el-Mandeb. The IOM reports more than 200,000 people displaced by the recent fighting. The Houthis have warned international airlines against using Saudi airspace, a threat we judge they will try to make credible with further strikes.
- Press reporting citing three US officials indicates Saudi Arabia and Syria are discussing the deployment of 10,000 to 20,000 Syrian troops to Yemen, drawing on divisions near Damascus and in the south. Both capitals consulted Washington, which does not object in principle; CENTCOM has been consulted. Damascus publicly denied joining the war on 7 October while voicing support for Riyadh. President al-Sharaa has not signed off, and we judge the leak is partly intended to test Houthi and Iranian reactions.
- For the United States, the appeal of a Syrian contribution is a larger anti-Houthi ground force without deeper American involvement; the President weighed and shelved US strikes on the Houthis in September. The risk is a Syrian army barely a year into reconstitution taking casualties in Yemen, with knock-on effects for Syria's own stability and for Israeli-Syrian security understandings.

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We expect the Houthis to pair airport strikes with renewed attacks on Red Sea shipping if the coastal offensive threatens Hodeidah. A decision point for Riyadh comes if civilian casualties at Saudi airports mount: the Kingdom would then face pressure either to escalate air operations in Houthi-held territory or to seek a pause that would stall the offensive.

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Russia Follows Mass Missile Barrage With Kramatorsk Bus Strike; Kyiv Hits a Yandex Data Center

We assess Russia has opened its winter strike campaign early and is pairing it with terror strikes on frontline cities to depopulate Ukraine's Donetsk "fortress belt." On the morning of 8 October a Russian glide bomb struck two minibuses at a public transport stop in Kramatorsk, killing at least 33 people and wounding 18 to 22, according to Ukraine's emergency service and regional officials; Kramatorsk and Sloviansk suspended all public transport. The attack followed the night of 6 to 7 October, when Russia launched 48 cruise missiles, an unspecified number of ballistic missiles, and 130 strike drones, 46 of them jet-powered, against energy and civilian targets in Kyiv, Kharkiv, Poltava, Dnipropetrovsk, and Chernihiv oblasts. A missile on an apartment block in Pryluky killed at least 20 people, including children.

- The barrage used multiple high-volume waves against a smaller target set, a pattern we judge Russia will repeat against the grid through the winter. Ukraine's ombudsman reports Russian strikes caused more civilian casualties from January to August 2026 (about 15,280 killed and wounded) than in all of 2025, a 55-percent year-on-year increase.
- Ukraine retaliated at scale. Drones struck Yandex's Sasovo data center in Ryazan oblast, the first major attack on a Russian data hub of the war, causing a fire and suspending operations at a site hosting tens of thousands of servers; Yandex says it cannot yet determine whether equipment is recoverable. Russia's defense ministry claimed 399 Ukrainian fixed-wing drones downed overnight. Overhead imagery confirms the fire at the Sasovo site. Ukraine also hit oil infrastructure in Samara and Astrakhan oblasts and a tanker in Sochi port, and Russia says a Ukrainian naval drone struck a Liberian-flagged tanker off its Black Sea coast.
- The naval war is spreading west. Zelensky confirmed a 6 October drone and naval-drone strike on two vessels in Bulgaria's exclusive economic zone (one sunk, one badly damaged). Bulgarian President Yotova called it a "significant deterioration" in Black Sea security but withheld attribution pending investigation. If Russian responsibility is confirmed, strikes on civilian shipping in a NATO member's waters raise the risk of an incident that engages Article 4 consultations.
- On the ground, Russian pressure continues around Kupiansk, Kostyantynivka, and Dobropillya without confirmed advances, and Ukrainian forces advanced east of

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Oleksandrivka in Dnipropetrovsk oblast. Press reporting indicates Russia is shifting forces, including Spetsnaz elements, toward the Slovyansk-Kramatorsk axis.

For Washington, the Kramatorsk strike will sharpen congressional pressure to enforce the new Russia sanctions law ahead of its 18 October deadline. We expect Kyiv to request additional interceptors immediately and to continue long-range strikes on Russian energy and now digital infrastructure, which Moscow will cite to justify further strikes on Ukraine's grid.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

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Europe Hardens Against Russia's Sabotage Campaign as Washington Explores a Nord Stream Deal

We assess European allies are moving from warning to institutional response on Russian hybrid operations, and that a simultaneous US-Russia conversation about Nord Stream risks a serious rift with Berlin. Denmark's security service PET said on 7 October that Russia has begun sabotage operations against Danish defense firms supplying Ukraine, having concluded that broader disruption failed to deter Western support; PET describes a shift from planning to execution over the summer and the use of untrained intermediaries recruited over Telegram. On 8 October Prime Minister Burnham and Chancellor Merz launched a UK-Germany security partnership to share intelligence and coordinate action against sabotage and cyberattacks, naming Russia as the principal threat, and ratified the 2025 Kensington Treaty.

- EU ambassadors on 7 October endorsed the largest Russia sanctions package since 2022: roughly 1,646 listings, including 743 individuals, 826 defense-industrial entities (more than half tied to missile production), and 77 State Duma members elected in occupied Ukrainian territory. Foreign ministers are due to adopt it on 12 October. Ambassadors also cleared the way to open accession clusters 2 and 3 for Ukraine and Moldova on 13 October after Hungary lifted its veto.
- Press reporting citing five sources indicates Special Envoy Kushner and Kremlin envoy Dmitriev discussed bringing a US investor into the Nord Stream pipelines during recent meetings in Moscow and New York. A White House official said any deal must run through DFC and Treasury and that there had been "no Nord Stream discussions recently"; a US official judged a deal unlikely in the medium term. Germany's coalition opposes any restart; only the AfD supports it.
- We judge the Nord Stream reporting, even without a deal, will be read in Berlin and Copenhagen as Washington monetizing a peace it has not yet delivered while they absorb Russian sabotage. It will complicate the UK-German effort to present a united front and gives Moscow a wedge to work in the days before the EU sanctions vote.

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A Royal Navy service member was charged this week with spying for an unnamed foreign state, and Germany earlier accused Russia of launching an explosives-laden drone at Leipzig/Halle airport. We expect further public attributions by European services in the coming weeks as governments build the case for a coordinated response; the question for Washington is whether to join it.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, NSA, FBI, INR, Treasury OIA, and open sources.

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Seoul Recalls Its Ambassador From Kyiv and Flies Its First Hypersonic Weapon

We assess the South Korea-Ukraine rupture is a genuine rift rather than theater, and that it will constrain Seoul's support to Kyiv at a moment Washington wants allies aligned. South Korea announced on 8 October that it is recalling Ambassador Park Hee-chang from Kyiv in protest at President Zelensky's 23 September disclosure at the UN General Assembly that Ukraine had transferred two captured North Korean soldiers to the South. Seoul says Kyiv broke a non-disclosure agreement and endangered the soldiers' families in North Korea; Kyiv denies any such agreement existed. President Lee had demanded a public apology; Foreign Minister Cho said Ukraine's apology fell short. The embassy stays open and the ministry frames the recall as a protest, not a rupture.

- The dispute lands as Seoul faces its own scrutiny: Ukraine's sanctions commissioner said on 6 October that Russia imported more than 176,000 tons of petroleum products from South Korean ports in July and August, 31 percent of Russia's August fuel imports. We judge the ambassador's recall partly serves to shift attention from that exposure.
- The same day, President Lee attended the first flight test of South Korea's domestically developed hypersonic weapon, which separated from its booster, maneuvered vertically and horizontally, and struck a test target; his office said it would be able to hit key peninsula targets by surprise once fielded. Lee also inspected the Hyunmoo-5 ballistic missile and stressed securing "our security through our own strength."
- The test answers North Korea's 3 October launch of what it called a hypersonic intermediate-range missile (Pyongyang claims more than 1,000 km; Seoul and Tokyo detected about 700). Tensions also remain elevated after last month's mine blasts that wounded three South Korean soldiers, which the South and UN Command attribute to devices planted by the North.

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For Washington, a Seoul-Kyiv estrangement weakens the case for South Korean munitions support to Ukraine and gives Pyongyang and Moscow a propaganda opening. We expect the dispute to be contained within weeks if Kyiv offers a fuller apology; Seoul's accelerating independent-strike capabilities are the more durable trend and will feature in alliance conversations about extended deterrence and conventional burden-sharing.

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Eritrean Forces Enter Tigray, Pushing Ethiopia and Eritrea Toward Direct War

We assess Ethiopia and Eritrea are closer to open interstate war than at any time since 2018. Conflict monitors report Eritrean forces crossed the border at Zalambessa on 7 October and were struck by Ethiopian drones at Guada as they moved toward Idaga Hamus. Residents of Adigrat told the press they saw convoys carrying dozens of soldiers in Eritrean uniforms moving south through the town, and a Tigray Peace Force commander said Eritrean personnel reached Adigrat on 6 October and Idaga Hamus on 7 October. Addis Ababa demanded that "all foreign military forces operating within our sovereign territory must withdraw immediately"; Asmara dismissed "wild allegations" without denying them.

- Troop numbers and orders remain unconfirmed, and Eritrea has not acknowledged the deployment. We judge Asmara's aim is to shape Tigray into a buffer hostile to Addis Ababa and to pre-empt what it believes are Ethiopian designs on Red Sea access via Eritrean territory.
- Ethiopian drone strikes on Eritrean columns inside Ethiopia are the first confirmed direct exchange in this round. Each side's incentive to strike first is rising; a miscalculation in the Adigrat corridor could produce large-scale fighting within days.
- A new Horn war would open a second front on the Red Sea while the Houthi campaign and the Yemen counteroffensive are under way, threaten the Djibouti basing environment, and draw in Gulf patrons on opposing sides. Humanitarian conditions in Tigray, still recovering from the 2020-22 war, would deteriorate quickly.

Watch for Ethiopian mobilization announcements, Eritrean conscription call-ups, and any Tigrayan factions aligning with Asmara. For Washington, early and visible diplomatic engagement with both capitals, coordinated with Gulf partners who fund each side, is the one lever likely to work before fighting spreads.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

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WHO Still Lacks Answers on Russia's Plague-Lab Death as Moscow Closes the Case

We assess Russia has decided to close the Irkutsk episode administratively without providing the data that would let outside experts rule out a laboratory-acquired plague infection. A researcher at the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute died of severe pneumonia on 2 October; press accounts say she may have broken a vial of live plague bacteria. On 7 October the WHO formally asked Moscow about reports of a second institute employee with pneumonia of undetermined cause, and Director-General Tedros said "many questions remain." Rospotrebnadzor called the second-case reports "incorrect," said the researcher had been vaccinated against the pathogens she handled, reported no transmissions among 197 isolated contacts, and announced it is winding down preventive measures in the region.

- The United States issued a *démarche* on 6 October stating that Russia's failure to disclose details violates its international health obligations. The President said he does not believe the death involved a bioweapon, expects to raise it with President Putin, and would share US intelligence; the Kremlin says no call is scheduled and warned against "false information."
- Press reporting indicates several Central Asian states issued travel advisories or border measures earlier in the week. We judge the public-health risk is low if Moscow's contact-tracing claims are accurate, but Russia's refusal to share clinical and laboratory data is consistent with its handling of past incidents and will keep neighbors on alert.
- The case is a test of whether the International Health Regulations still function with Moscow. Russia's claim that it informed WHO "in accordance with established practice" while denying the agency specifics suggests it will treat the matter as closed unless pressed at head-of-state level.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA's National Center for Medical Intelligence, INR, and open sources.

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Notes

Maduro and Flores charged with conspiracy to torture. Federal prosecutors in Manhattan unsealed a superseding indictment on 8 October adding a conspiracy-to-commit-torture count against Nicolás Maduro and Cilia Flores, who were captured by US forces in Caracas on 3 January and already face narcotics and weapons charges. The indictment alleges electric shocks, asphyxiation, starvation, beatings, and rape of detainees, including three unnamed Americans, and says Maduro ordered specific detentions and received reports on their treatment. A judge denied Flores's request for release on health grounds; trial is set for next year. The charges harden the US case against negotiating any exit for the couple and will be read in Caracas as closing the door on a brokered transition.

Washington opens direct talks with Myanmar's junta. Press reporting indicates the administration has begun direct engagement with the military-installed government, focused on scam compounds targeting Americans and potentially on rare-earth minerals. The outreach is likely to unsettle ASEAN partners and anti-junta forces; the yield, if any, will be measured in extraditions and access to mining concessions that China currently dominates.

UK withdraws most diplomats from its Jerusalem consulate. Israeli Foreign Minister Saar said on 8 October that most British diplomats will leave the consulate, with seven remaining on limited activity; Foreign Secretary Miliband said some staff were "temporarily withdrawn" for security reasons. Israel is likely to present the move as a downgrade of a mission it has long objected to; London will resist that framing. It comes as Palestinian legislative elections planned for November remain in doubt because Israel has refused election officials access to East Jerusalem and Gaza.

Kenya confirms its first Ebola case. A man who traveled from the Democratic Republic of Congo died in a Nairobi hospital, Kenya's first confirmed Ebola case. Nairobi is a regional air hub and a major US diplomatic and military platform; contact tracing in the coming days will determine whether this remains an imported case.

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Spain heads toward a general strike before its snap election. Maricarmen Abascal, 87, whose eviction on 23 September triggered nationwide housing protests and Prime Minister Sánchez's decision to call a 29 November election, died on 7 October; the UGT and CCOO unions called a nationwide general strike for 11 November. Housing is now the dominant issue of the campaign, and a strike-driven run-up favors the parties of protest at the expense of the government, with implications for Spain's defense-spending commitments to NATO.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, FBI, INR, DHS, and open sources.